



AFP PHOTO/ LORENZO TUGNOLI

HIGH IMPACT: BY TARGETING THE TWO LUXURY HOTELS, THE TERROR SQUAD PLANNED AN INDIAN VERSION OF THE TWIN TOWER ATTACKS

PANIC-STRICKEN GUESTS USE BEDSHEETS IN A DESPERATE ATTEMPT TO ESCAPE FROM THE TAJ HOTEL

next morning. Guests, including six foreigners, and hotel and kitchen staff are among the dead. Panic-stricken guests tried to escape from windows—one used a bedsheet to climb down from his third-floor room at the Taj, but slipped and fell. At 1.30 p.m. on Thursday, Mumbai Police chief A.N. Roy announced that the Taj Hotel had been sanitised and all guests were evacuated but an hour later explosions were still being heard. The damage, however, was equally psychological. All through the night, vehicular traffic was paralysed and the city seemed to have imposed a curfew on itself. By midnight, the biggest anti-terror operation in Indian history was underway. "Hardcore, highly trained, and motivated," is how Vice-Admiral J.S. Bedi, flag officer commanding-in-chief, Western Naval Command, describes the terrorists.

At the time of going to press, the hostage crisis had not ended, showing just how serious this latest attack is and its larger implications. As one police official said, "They (the terrorists) have succeeded, we have failed." INDIA TODAY is in possession of an intelligence report from the Mumbai Police which warned of attacks from the sea based on interrogations of terrorists arrested earlier (*see box*). How the boats ferrying the terrorists managed to evade the coast-

guard, navy and customs officials who patrol the harbour is a gross security failure and raises some serious questions.

Who is behind the attack? The strikes have shaken the country's intelligence and security agencies like nothing before. They were unprepared for such an unprecedented commando-like operation. "The meticulous manner in which the operation has been planned and the guerrilla tactics that have been used has footprints of Al-Qaeda, making it perhaps their first operation in India," said a senior intelligence official, pointing to the fact that places frequented by foreigners were targeted. Sources said that the Research and Analysis Wing had received inputs six months ago that a group of terrorists—part of the Al-Qaeda's Islamic Jihad Union—was being trained along the Pakistan-Afghanistan border to carry out attacks in India. "The issue was discussed at a Joint Intelligence Committee meeting but was treated as unactionable," says a high-placed official. The terrorists landed in small dinghies each carrying four to five persons. "Terrorism in India has reached a new level with these attacks. This is terror in the real sense where common people in public places can be sprayed